Whole-grain intake is associated with body mass index in college students.

OBJECTIVE: To measure whole-grain intake in college students and determine the association with body mass index (BMI). DESIGN: Cross-sectional convenience sample of college students enrolled in an introductory nutrition course. SETTING: Large state university. PARTICIPANTS: 159 college students, mean age: 19.9. MAIN OUTCOME MEASURES: Intake of whole grains, refined grains, calories, and fiber from food records; BMI determined from height and weight measurements. ANALYSIS: Analysis of variance with linear contrasts; participants grouped by BMI category ($P<.05$). RESULTS: Average intake of cereal grains was 5.4 servings per day, of which whole-grain intake accounted for an average of 0.7 servings per day. Whole-grain intake was significantly higher in normal weight students than in overweight and obese students (based on BMI). CONCLUSIONS AND IMPLICATIONS: The low intake of whole grains in this population of college students indicates the need for interventions aiming to increase whole-grain intake to the recommended minimum of 3 servings per day. College students who are concerned about their body weight may be motivated to increase their intake of whole-grain foods; however, their intake of whole grains is likely to be influenced by the availability of these food items in campus dining halls and other locations around the college campus.